

Aalto Executive MBA in Seoul, Helsinki Residence Program 2026

Track: Entrepreneurship Go-to-Market Strategies

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Dr. Antti Lähtevänoja's research focuses on emerging sales methodologies and their intersection with technology, particularly AI. He explores how sales organizations can better serve today's hyper-informed buyers through revised sales strategies and the effective adoption of new technologies.

His recent work centres on educational selling: a methodology that creates value in the sales interaction by teaching the client throughout the process, improving both relational and business outcomes. At Aalto, he teaches practical-oriented entrepreneurship and startup courses.

Beyond academia, Antti is a seasoned sales professional with a background spanning multiple tech companies. He has successfully exited a fintech venture (Invested, 2023), currently supports early-stage founders and advises a number of AI-focused startups.

Class Dates

Weekday	Date	Local Time
Friday	July 31, 2026	08.30 – 16.30 EEST
Saturday	August 1, 2026	08.30 – 16.30 EEST
Monday	August 3, 2026	08.30 – 16.30 EEST

Venue

The module is held at Aalto EE's premises, located on Runeberginkatu 14-16, 00100 Helsinki Finland.

Deadlines

Task	Date	Submission
Pre-assignment	July 20, 2026, by 10.00 KST	Aalto Canvas
Final Examination	August 4, 2026, by 23.59 EEST	Aalto Canvas

Module Overview

The Entrepreneurship Module focuses on building Go-To-Market (GTM) strategies for new products or services in B2B markets. Through an intensive three-day format combining keynote-style teaching, practical assignments, and AI tool workshops, students analyze GTM programs of companies operating in global B2B markets and apply these learnings to develop their own business models, revenue strategies, and market-entry plans. Students learn to leverage AI tools, apply metrics and feedback loops to refine their strategies, and assess scalability and risks. By the end of this module, participants are equipped with practical frameworks to launch new products in competitive global markets, whether founding their own ventures or driving innovation within established organizations.

Module Objectives

By the end of the three days, participants will be able to:

- Size a B2B market defensibly using a TAM/SAM/SOM calculation, documenting assumptions and capture rates against benchmarks.
- Map the competitive landscape of a chosen market using Porter's Five Forces, and identify the strategic implications for entry or growth.
- Define a clear ICP and buyer personas for a B2B product or service, distinguishing between different decision-making units.
- Convert value proposition and business model into an executable pricing and sales strategy.
- Build a B2B marketing strategy with appropriate channel mix, content strategy, and a defensible set of metrics that align marketing and sales.
- Apply a modern B2B sales process that accounts for the online, rep-free buying journey and multiple decision-makers.
- Leverage AI tools across the GTM stack – for market research, ICP refinement, content drafting, and sales prospecting, while critically evaluating where AI adds value and where it adds noise.
- Produce and present a coherent GTM plan for a fictional company, defending key assumptions in front of peers, putting the theoretical learnings into action.

Teaching Methods and Materials

Methods

The course uses a mix of methods:

- Lectures and practical in-class tasks for each framework, drawing on real cases
- Structured group discussion in pairs and at-table to surface participants' own examples and tensions in the frameworks.
- Case company teamwork at the end of each day, applying the day's frameworks to one of three fictional case companies. Teams are formed on Day 1 morning and stay together.
- Peer feedback and presentations on Day 3 afternoon, where each team presents a 10-minute draft GTM plan and receives challenge from peers and facilitator.

Materials provided

- Pre-work brief – the pre-Day 1 assignment, with the three case companies summarised.
- TAM/SAM/SOM companion for the pre-work for those new to market sizing.
- Case company briefs – the full backstories of the fictional case companies
- Participant workbook – concrete takeaway from the course, including frameworks, examples and glossary
- Slide deck handouts (PDF) – presentation slides from each day

Mandatory Pre-readings and Videos

TAM, SAM, SOM – how to calculate market size, WaveUp, 2026

<https://waveup.com/blog/tam-sam-som/>

A current, clear walk-through of bottom-up market sizing with examples and common pitfalls.

Gartner Sales Survey – 67% of B2B Buyers Prefer a Rep-Free Experience, Gartner press release, 2026

<https://www.gartner.com/en/newsroom/press-releases/2026-03-09-gartner-sales-survey-finds-67-percent-of-b2b-buyers-prefer-a-rep-free-experience>

Reports current data on how B2B buyers actually behave, and outlines the implications for sales and marketing organisations. Useful to anchor the whole course, but especially important before Day 3 when we go deep on modern sales process.

Traditional B2B Sales and Marketing Are Becoming Obsolete, Brent Adamson, Harvard Business Review (Feb 2022)

<https://hbr.org/2022/02/traditional-b2b-sales-and-marketing-are-becoming-obsolete>

A clear summary of how B2B buying has changed and what it means for sellers. Draws on Gartner research showing buyers spend only 17% of their total purchase time meeting with potential suppliers. Adamson argues the response is not better selling against the old model but a deep reconfiguration of how supplier organizations engage buyers.

How Superhuman Built an Engine to Find Product/Market Fit, Rahul Vohra – First Round Review

<https://review.firstround.com/how-superhuman-built-an-engine-to-find-product-market-fit/>

The most-cited practitioner piece on PMF since 2018. Rahul Vohra walks through how Superhuman used the Sean Ellis test as the core metric of a four-step engine that took their PMF score from 22% to 58%. The most actionable single article on measuring and improving PMF.

How to create detailed buyer personas, HubSpot – Marketing Blog

<https://blog.hubspot.com/marketing/buyer-persona-research>

A practical guide to building buyer personas. Includes a downloadable template and an AI-assisted persona generator. Useful as a working tool when you are translating ICP and DMU thinking from the slides into a documented persona for your own product.

Additional, Recommended Readings (not provided by Aalto EE)

How Stripe grew from 7 lines of code to a \$74 billion valuation, Aspire

<https://www.thisisaspire.com/blog/stripe-case-study>

A more analytical case study that focuses on how Stripe's value proposition evolved as the product expanded from API to Connect to Atlas. Useful for thinking through how a value proposition needs to grow with the product rather than stay frozen at the launch line.

How to Miss by a Mile: An Alternative Look at Uber's Potential Market Size, *Bill Gurley, Above the Crowd, 2014*

<https://abovethecrowd.com/2014/07/11/how-to-miss-by-a-mile-an-alternative-look-at-ubers-potential-market-size/>

The classic counter-argument to top-down market sizing, written by Benchmark partner Bill Gurley in response to an analyst who had pegged Uber's TAM at the existing taxi market. Gurley argues the analyst missed by a mile because the taxi market is not Uber's TAM – Uber expands the market by changing the product. A useful piece for thinking through how a market sizing must account for behavioural shifts the new offering creates, rather than freezing the addressable market at the size of the incumbent category.

How to Do Market Research for a Startup, *Catherine Cote, Harvard Business School Online, 2022*

<https://online.hbs.edu/blog/post/how-to-do-market-research-for-a-startup>

A clean primer on the difference between primary and secondary market research, and when each one earns its keep in an early-stage business. Walks through interview design, survey construction, and how to triangulate findings without over-investing in any single source. Useful for participants who have done market sizing but never sat across from a customer to test whether the assumptions actually hold.

5 Pricing Strategy Mistakes Costing SaaS Companies Growth, *Kyle Poyar – SaaS Club Podcast*

<https://saasclub.io/podcast/saas-pricing-strategy-mistakes-kyle-poyar/>

Kyle Poyar's catalogue of the five most common mistakes he sees across OpenView's portfolio. The single most useful insight: enterprise B2B buyers actively avoid products priced too low because they read low price as a signal of low staying-power.

More readings will be recommended throughout the course.

Assignments

Pre-assignment

This course moves quickly, and Day 1 begins with market sizing. To make the most of that first session, in addition to reading all the mandatory readings, please complete the short exercise below.

Read the [WaveUp piece](#) on bottom-up market sizing (one of the mandatory readings). Then, in a few short paragraphs (one page max), pick a market you know – your employer's, a startup you follow, or one you're considering. Name the market in one line, then answer: would top-down or bottom-up be the more honest way to size it, and why? Is there a published industry figure that genuinely captures the opportunity, or does the market need to be counted up from customers and units? Name the specific feature of the market that drives your answer.

Please submit your written pre-assignment to Aalto Canvas on 20 July, by 10.00 KST at the latest. Kindly note that late submission will drastically affect your grade.

In-class Assignments

The in-class assignments are presentations given by each of the teams to show the results of their workshopping done during the sessions.

Final Exam

The final assignment will be published in Canvas in the morning of the examination day, Tuesday 4th of August in addition to instructions on the use of AI.

Please submit your individual, written final assignment to Aalto Canvas on Tuesday 4th of August by 23.59 EEST at the latest. Kindly note that you may choose where to do the exam, and you are not expected to come to Aalto EE's premises. Please also note that late submission will drastically affect your module grade.

Assessment and Grading

Components of Course Grade

- Pre-assignment 20%
- Individual Class Contribution 10%
- In-class group assignment(s) 20%
- Final exam 50%

Evaluation of the Pre-assignment

The pre-assignment will be evaluated against these four criteria, weighted equally:

Criterion	What good looks like	Weight
Market is clearly named and bounded	Specific market named in one line, scope is clear (geography, segment, product category) – not vague ("the software market")	25%
Reasoning shows understanding of both methods	Demonstrates that the participant understands what each method actually does – not just which one they prefer	25%
A specific market feature drives the answer	Names one concrete feature of the market (regulation, behavioural shift, fragmentation, novelty, etc.) that explains the choice of calculation method.	25%
Writing is clear and disciplined	Not too short (under half page) and stays within one page. Coherent prose The reader can follow the logic in one pass.	25%

Evaluation of Individual Class Participation

Individual class participation refers a student's degree of engagement with in-class discussions, presentations, workshops, and other activities at an individual level. You are expected to actively participate in discussions, speak up, and contribute your own views about the class topics during in-class interactions.

Evaluation of In-Class Group Assignments

Group work, such as team presentations is evaluated as a whole for the entire team. All participants are expected to be actively engaged and contribute during the sessions.

Evaluation of Final Examination

The assessment matrix for the final examination will be shown in the final examination instructions.

Grading

Please note that in order to pass the final exam the student should get at least 50% of the required marks. One re-attempt is allowed in case of failing (0). No re-takes are allowed in case a participant passes the module with a grade of 1 or higher.

Class Attendance

Class attendance is critical. Local EMBA Team must be informed in advance via email of any missed segments; otherwise, class attendance is regarded as mandatory. In case of a sudden situation, the notification must be sent as soon as possible, even after the absence.

Absences exceeding a certain limit (see below) will affect the module grade negatively. Three possible outcomes may follow due to an absence:

- No effect on final module grade for a maximum absence of 3,5 hours in Aalto Executive MBA
- Downgrading the final module grade by 5 points for an absence of >3,5–6 hours in Aalto Executive MBA
- Downgrading the final module grade by 10 points for an absence of >6–8 hours in Aalto Executive MBA. The reason for such an absence must be exceptional.

All absences during the module days count towards the total amount of absence hour. Absences exceeding 8 hours or one full module day in the Aalto Executive MBA are not allowed.

Aalto University official policy on use of AI in teaching and learning (amended for Aalto EE use)

Advanced language models, such as ChatGPT and other models that generate images, videos, and audio, have reached a level where their produced content can be difficult to distinguish from human-generated content. Software and services based on artificial intelligence are expected to continue to develop and increase in the future, and so their use should also be considered in teaching and research. In this text, the term artificial intelligence refers to software and services that utilise AI, of which currently the best-known examples include ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini, DeepL, Dall-e, Bard, Midjourney, and grammar aids used in text processing software.

1. The use of AI-based technologies is allowed as a support for teaching and learning unless instructed otherwise by the instructor of the course. The instructor of the course may decide on restrictions on the use of technology on a course- or task-specific basis if achieving the learning objectives of the course requires it. • **If the instructor decides to restrict the use of AI on a course- or task-specific basis,** they must provide clear instructions on the limitations in connection with the assessment criteria and time the guidance so that the participant has the possibility to complete the task as instructed. The instructor may ask the participant to describe how AI has been used in the learning task.

2. The participant is always responsible for the content of their submitted work. • For example, language models can be used for formatting or ideation of the text produced, unless otherwise instructed by the instructor. However, AI-generated text cannot be presented as is as the participant's own written response. The participant is obligated to follow academic writing practices (e.g. cite AI produced text like any other source: "OpenAI. (2023). *ChatGPT* (Mar 14 version) [Large language model]."). Upon the instructor's request, the participant is obligated to describe how, what and/or why AI-based technology has been used to do the learning task.

3. Utilizing AI in a learning task contrary to the instructor's instructions will be considered cheating and will be handled in accordance with the current procedures. • The official text-plagiarism detection tool Turnitin used by Aalto University has a tool for instructors that identifies text produced by AI. By using this system, the instructor has the opportunity to assess whether a language model has been used to produce the text.

*Participants must **request permission from the instructor** before recording any lecture or session (including audio, video, or screen capture).*

Additional information

Kindly note that the schedule below comprises only the schedule for the module days. Information of the possible extracurricular activities, such as Aalto greetings toast and a campus visit, will be announced separately.

Module Schedule

Each day includes a one-hour lunch break. Additional breaks will be held flexibly.

Friday, July 31, 2026, 08.30-16.30

08:30 – 10:00

- Introduction and group allocation
- Market sizing (TAM/SAM/SOM, bottom-up vs top-down)
- Market environment and competition (PESTEL, Porter's Five Forces)

11:00 – 12:00 Lunch

12:00 – 16:30

- From market to customer (segmentation, ICP, buyer personas)
- Case company teamwork: size the market and draft the ICP for your team's company

Saturday, August 1, 2026, 08.30-16.30

08:30 – 10:00

- Product–market fit (signals, leading indicators, fit stages)
- Pricing and revenue models (tiered, packaging, value-based reasoning)
- From market to customer (segmentation, ICP, buyer personas)

11:00 – 12:00 Lunch

12:00 – 16:30

- B2B marketing strategy (positioning, messaging, channel selection)
- Marketing content, demand generation, and measurement (funnel logic, key metrics, CRM/marketing automation basics)
- AI in the GTM stack (realistic 2026 view of where AI helps in sales, marketing, ops)
- Case company teamwork: define pricing model and top 3 marketing channels

Monday, August 3, 2026, 08.30-16.30

08:30 – 10:00

- Product–market fit (signals, leading indicators, fit stages)
- Pricing and revenue models (tiered, packaging, value-based reasoning)
- From market to customer (segmentation, ICP, buyer personas)

11:00 – 12:00 Lunch

12:00 – 16:30

- Modern B2B sales (the changed buying journey, buying committees, the rep-free preference)
- Sales process, pipeline, and metrics (MEDDIC/MEDDPICC high-level, sales KPIs, sales-marketing alignment)
- Professional purchasing in B2B (how procurement works, RFP dynamics, negotiating with sophisticated buyers)
- Team presentations + peer Q&A, then synthesis and "what to do Monday morning"
- Wrap-up and instructions for the final exam

PD Corner



Welcome to your second module of the Entrepreneurship track offered in your Helsinki Residence Program.

We hope that the learnings of what this track has to offer carry a long way, and that you will think that your Helsinki Residence Program was time well spent!

Wishing you a wonderful module ahead!

Sincerely,
Andreea and Your EMBA team for the Helsinki Residence Program

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